

Sambucus nigra (Caprifoliaceae)

Elder

Elder has more folklore attached to it than almost any other European plant, except perhaps mandrake (*Mandragora officinarum*, p. 232). Chopping elder branches was considered dangerous in rural England as it was believed that the tree was inhabited by the Elder Mother, and to avoid her wrath, woodcutters would recite a placatory rhyme. Elder is a valuable remedy for flu, colds, and chest conditions.



Elder was traditionally known as "Nature's medicine chest."

Habitat & Cultivation

Native to Europe, elder thrives in woods, hedges, and in open areas. It is now found in most temperate regions, and is often cultivated. Elder is propagated from cuttings in spring. The flowering tops are harvested in late spring and the berries are picked in early autumn.

Key Constituents**Berries:**

- Flavonoids
- Anthocyanins
- Lectins
- Vitamins A and C

Flowers:

- Flavonoids
- Anthocyanins
- Triterpenes
- Volatile oil (0.7%)
- Mucilage
- Tannins

Key Actions

- Antiviral
- Clears mucus
- Anti-inflammatory

- Diuretic
- Increases sweating

Research

■ **Elder berries** Israeli research from 1995 found 90% of people that were given elderberry extract recovered in 2–3 days, while 90% of those taking the placebo took up to 6 days. Further clinical trials have supported these findings—a 2014 review concluded there was "good scientific evidence" that elderberry extract was an effective treatment for influenza. Although the safety profile of elderberry has not been established, evidence indicates it is a safe influenza remedy for adults and children.

Traditional & Current Uses

■ **Coughs & colds** The berries have an established antiviral activity, helping prevent and speed recovery from upper respiratory infections, such as colds and flu. Following traditional usage, the flowers are taken to stimulate sweating and relieve fever by cooling the body. An elderflower infusion makes a soothing remedy when suffering from cold and flu.

■ **Congestion & allergies** The flowering tops tone the mucous linings of the nose and throat (increasing their resistance to infection) and are prescribed for chronic congestion, ear infections, and allergies. Infusions with other herbs can reduce severity of hay fever attacks if taken some months before the season.

■ **Arthritis** By encouraging sweating and urine production, elder flowering tops aid removal

**Elder**

A deciduous tree growing to 33 ft (10 m), with oval leaves, cream flowers, and blue-black berries.

Parts Used**Flowering tops**

reduce fevers and help coughs, colds, and flu.

Flowers reduce inflammation



Dried flowering tops

Berries are nutritious and may be used as a mild laxative.



Dried berries

Fresh flowering tops

Berries contain vitamins A and C



Fresh berries

Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Cautions** None known. Do not consume unripe berries.



Infusion of flowering tops (to make, p. 291). For colds, drink ¾ cup (150 ml) 3 times a day.



Cream made with flowering tops (see p. 296). Apply freely to chapped skin.



Tincture of flowering tops (to make, p. 292). For hay fever, take 1 tsp with water 3–4 times a day.



Decoction of berries (to make, p. 291). For rheumatic aches, take ½ cup (100 ml) 3 times a day.

of waste products and are of value in arthritic conditions.

■ **Other uses** Flowers and berries are mildly laxative and appear to help lower blood pressure. The flowers are thought to help control diabetes. The berries appear to enhance immune function.

Self-help Uses

- **Allergic rhinitis, including hay fever**, p. 300.
- **Colds, flu, & fevers**, p. 311.
- **Colds & congestion in children**, p. 318.
- **Earache due to chronic congestion**, p. 312.